



Calvin Klein USB Shades

The old routine of putting on your shades if they are off and pulling them off if they are on just got another step thrown in. Take off an arm, and slip it into the computer, transfer some data, and then continue with the routine.

pay for though, and this drive is our Best Performance winner, across categories, by miles. If you're impatient like I am, don't even think of buying another drive.

Kingston Data Traveler Vault Privacy

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To explain the comment in the previous review, this drive is most certainly not for "normal use". Corporate employees, those handling sensitive data and conspiracy theorists rejoice. This is a drive that's made for one purpose only, to keep your data secure. Probably aimed at government and department of defence personnel, this drive features 256-bit AES hardware encryption; to put that in perspective, most banks feel 128-bit is good enough for financial data transactions.

With features such as automatic drive formatting after 10 intrusion attempts, enforced complex password protection, an aluminium casing and the ability to stay safe up to four feet underwater, you know Kingston means business with this product.

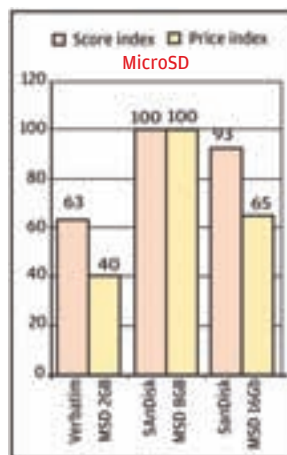
confidential data, this is one of the very few options you have. Hopefully, market prices are lower, and falling prices of flash memory might make this drive more affordable in the future.

Apacer AH522

Apacer is targeting the executive class with this drive. The golden sheen is derived from a "zinc alloy and electro-polished components", or so says their site - I'm no metallurgist.

The metallic body gives this drive a sturdy feel, and the capless design means that the USB head is hidden beneath the gold exterior. However, the slider mechanism doesn't feel as sturdy as, say, the SanDisk Crusier Titanium, or the Kingston HyperX. In all fairness, though, at a price of Rs. 1,299, I really shouldn't expect any better.

In terms of performance, this drive seems to have a split personality. It's better than the Voyager on almost all counts, and I don't think it's fair to expect to compete with the other three. This drive is the better of the two budget drives, and is actually the fastest drive across all categories in the assorted read test. I tested and re-tested to ensure this wasn't a freak occurrence, and those of you who read a lot



16 GB Fat flash

Falling prices have made this a very affordable category, while rising data usage has made



SanDisk Ultra Backup 16 GB

this category pretty popular. Perhaps as little as 6 months or a year down the line, I expect these to be the hot favourites.

SanDisk Ultra Backup 16 GB

SanDisk targets the Ultra Backup at those of us who have important data to backup. Available in 16, 32 and 64 GB versions, this drive features a dedicated backup button that's meant to make life easier. This is another capless (slider) design, and has a plastic body that seems rugged enough to withstand the occasional fall. It's not rugged enough to handle much more than that though.

The advantage of the plastic is that this drive is extremely light, and my dislike of moving parts on flash drives seems justified here, because the slider mechanism feels like cheap plastic.

Off topic for a bit, the reason I hate slider designs is because invariably, I have seen them go kaput. There's nothing more irritating than struggling to reach behind a cabinet to find USB ports, whilst holding down the broken slider mechanism of your flash drive so that you can connect it without pushing the

USB head back into the body. The lack of moving parts makes flash drives what they are.

Coming back to the drive, it's U3 capable, and also features optional 128-bit hardware encryption. Hardware encryption ensures that there's minimal loss of speed in the name of security. The software bundle includes a backup software that can do one touch backups, live backups and even backup versions of the selected files.

In terms of performance, the drive does pretty decently with sequential data, but coughs and splutters with assorted data. Considering that most people who would want to use a backup drive would write assorted data to it, the fact that it was the second slowest in the assorted write test is a dampener.

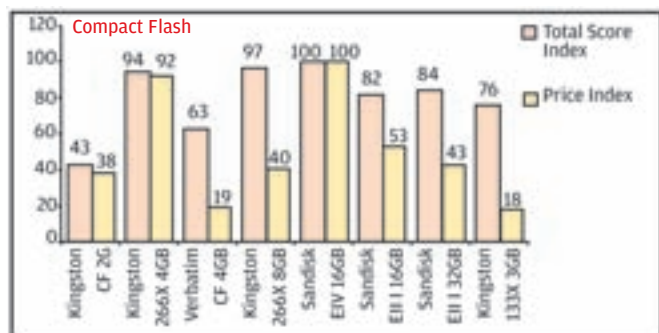
Weirdly enough, in a category where we never thought it possible, it's the good software that makes us want to recommend this drive. Priced at Rs. 2,499, this drive is a cheap buy, especially when you consider that it can do one-touch backup.

Transcend JetFlash 16 GB

This has got to be the plainest looking drive in the test. Like a blast from the past, this flash drive's design is simple, but also comes with the drawbacks that other manufacturers have been trying to rectify. For starters, the plastic body is just too flimsy to be considered sturdy enough to handle a fall. In fact, the plastic feels like it might crack under the slightest pressure from your thumb. The cap mechanism is also ancient, and those who buy this drive are surely going to lose / misplace their caps at some point in time.

This vanilla drive is actually Re. 1 more expensive than the SanDisk Ultra Backup, and I cannot, for the life of me, figure out why. It's slower than the SanDisk UB16 in every test, save the assorted write speed test. That's more to do with

the faults of the SanDisk Transcend JetFlash JF V30 16 GB



So how does it perform? Surprisingly, in spite of all the encryption and security features, this drive is no slacker. It's actually faster than the Apacer and Corsair Voyager, which is commendable.

At a price of Rs. 15,591, this drive can hardly be considered affordable. It's not meant for the everyday user at all, but if you're used to carrying a lot of

of small files from your flash drive might want to consider this as an option. For those on a budget, this drive will give you better performance results than the Voyager, and for just a few hundred more - maybe even less if you consider market prices.

Apacer AH522

